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YI T'AEJUN

Yi T'ae-jun (1904–?), who is also known by the pseudonym of Sanghŏ, was born to a humble family in Chŏrwŏn in the Kangwŏn province. He became an orphan at age eight and had to work for a living from the age of fourteen onward. In 1926 he entered Chosi University in Japan but had to drop out two years later due to financial difficulties. Despite these challenges, Yi went on to have an exceptionally successful literary career. He was a prolific writer of essays and novels, many of which won him critical respect and commercial fame. In 1931, aged twenty-seven, he became the chief editor of the literary section of the then major Korean newspaper, the *Chosŏn Chungang Ilbo* (1931–1937). From that position he was able to contribute to shaping the cultural scene of colonial Korea for years to come. Yi joined the North upon national division in 1948, and his fate there remains as of today somewhat obscure. In South Korea his works were banned until 1988, but since then his name has been reinstated to the national literary canon.

Throughout his career, Yi was a champion of autonomous literature, which he understood as a literature unconstrained by political agendas or commercial influences. In 1933 he founded and led the *Kuinhoe* (Group of nine), a circle of writers and artists devoted to innovation and experimentation in their disciplines. In promoting modernist writers such as Yi Sang and Pak T'aewŏn, the group brought new vitality to a literary scene that was growing weary of the formulaic productions of socialist literature. In the late 1930s, when the rising militarism dampened the earlier zeal for aesthetic radicalism, Yi launched the literary magazine *Munjang* (Style, 1939–1941) to continue to support writers of artistic integrity. This magazine served as the last stronghold of artistic autonomy amid the surging tides of the war until it was finally shut down in 1941. Afterward Yi retired to the countryside, where he spent the remaining colonial years in isolation.

"Before and after Liberation" (1946, Haebang chŏnhu) is a rare literary account of the situation of writers around the time of the end of the Japanese rule. Written as the memoir of a fictional writer, the piece tells a story of wartime oppression and mobilization, which are followed by the euphoria of liberation as well as the difficulties of rebuilding a Korean nation-state after thirty five years of colonial rule. At the story's core is a personal anecdote of broken friendship, which is emblematic of shifting alliances at a tumultuous time in Korean history. The work notably differs from Yi's earlier stories such as "Kkamagwi" (1936, trans. 1991 Crows) and "Poktŏkpang" (1937, The broker's office), none of which was concerned with politics. At the same time, retained here are many of the writer's distinctive traits, such as a sympathy for marginalized figures, a taste for classical literature, and an elegantly spare style of prose.

Before and After Liberation—A Writer's Memoir

(1946)

Although the word had been changed from "subpoena" to the less offensive "directive," it was always unpleasant to receive a writ of summons, which a policeman would drop off with disdain, as if coming on a petty errand. Hyŏn pretended to accept this summons with the usual indifference he maintained in the presence of his wife, who had turned pale even before he did; but he felt so unusually ill at ease that he wished to leave right away, so as to be done with the matter, instead of waiting until the next morning. Whether they called it a subpoena or a directive, all the same, timid Hyŏn was unable to accomplish a thing afterward, having no appetite that day and bad dreams that night.

Hyŏn was neither a theorist nor an ideologue. Nor was he a convict. His name seemed to have made its way onto their list of the usual suspects ever since they'd called him in under the suspicion for having corrupted the young—perhaps because his books or letters had been found in the houses of some recently arrested young men from the countryside, or because his name had come up during an investigation as one of their contacts in Seoul. Hyŏn supposed that had they wanted to imprison him, they would have done so right away instead of bothering with such things as subpoenas and directives. Still, he was thrown off-guard at each summons and was particularly worried this time. Though a mere novelist, he had been visited by more than a few young men, who were anxiously

fumbling for a solution to their complicated situation: as a result of the General Volunteer Law and the Special Student Volunteer Law, they must now not only die against their will but also kill Allied soldiers, such as the Chinese, the British, the Americans, and the Russians—in short, those who offered them their only hope; worse, their lives would be sacrificed for the sake of their enemy, Japan. One of Hyŏn's visitors suffered a nervous breakdown within days of receiving a draft notice, and another young man sent him a suicide note a week after they met. Hyŏn himself had not been drafted, but as a brother of these unfortunate students, he could not simply look out for himself and suppress his indignation in such a grave matter for all Koreans. At times, he wondered whether some strange visitor might not be a detective in disguise, sent to sound out his ideas. He quickly blamed himself for harboring such suspicions, though, and in the end neither modified nor omitted anything of what in his excitement he wanted to tell students. After such visits, Hyŏn sat alone in his quiet library, his face flushed and looking nervous for what he had just done. In his heart he felt inspired to commit himself to a higher, more useful task during this latest crisis for his people. But he had not prepared himself for any task in particular and could not suddenly break out of the hardened crust of his old self.

A life below the current is still not a sheltered life. An old proverb says, "A mulberry field can turn into a blue sea," but you can't change the sea back into a field by throwing a few pebbles into it. Everything is subject to its own destiny.

Thus quoting a passage he himself had recently written at the end of a short story, he smiled wryly at the insignificance of his life.

"You say it's only a matter of days, but what if those tenacious *kamikazes* hold out till the very end? What if they each knock out one ship? America, no matter how rich it is, can't make as many ships as there are Japanese pilots. Waiting for the fall of Japan is like waiting for the skies to fall!"

That day Hyŏn's wife begged her sleepless husband to sell the house and flee to the countryside. She asked him to move to some

remote village, far away from the authorities, where they could live in peace and have enough to eat from their own harvest, even if just for a day. Hyŏn had formerly entertained such an idea, too. Since he could not go abroad, he was bound to live under Japanese skies. Where, then, could he find such a remote village, like the one in the Age of Sage Kings, whose inhabitants had never seen an official and never had their peaceful sleep disturbed by even so much as the barking of a dog? All the same, whether or not there existed such a Shangri-la, it was getting more and more difficult for Hyŏn to continue living in Seoul. Since he remained determined to break his pen rather than write propaganda, or start writing in Japanese, he had long suffered a chronic lack of money. If he was going to have to sell the house, which was all that remained of his fortune, he'd rather sell everything at once, not piecemeal, and with that money buy up some land in the countryside. But just as with the crust of his old self, the enclosed shell of his life was not easy to break open.

"Let's wait a bit longer and see what happens." That was Hyŏn's attitude, which had long prompted his family to complain of his incompetence.

Detective Suruda of the Special Higher Division was in charge of Hyŏn's file at the Tongdaemun police station. He was not an intimidating man. In his chief's absence, he would be the first to greet Hyŏn in Korean, apologizing for asking him to come in again for such a trivial affair. But today, he ignored Hyŏn's deep bow and merely directed him to a chair with a sideways glance. The chief was in his office, commanding a formidable presence with his protruding forehead and sunken eyes.

Hyŏn sat down and waited, awkwardly kneading his hat, which was not khaki-colored as theirs were. Only after a while did Suruda stop writing. He asked Hyŏn what he was doing these days. Hyŏn answered that he was not doing anything in particular, so Suruda inquired about what he planned to do. When Hyŏn paused, "Well . . . " smiling in an attempt to be friendly, Suruda glanced back at

the chief. The chief was busy stamping his seal onto some document. The detective took out a file and opened it, hiding the file's contents from Hyŏn's sight behind its hard cover.

"Why aren't you doing something to help the current situation?" he asked.

"What power does someone like me have?"

"Don't talk like that. And please, do something. In fact, the provincial police department sent down an urgent directive to bring in a few key figures like you for questioning. They want to know things, like if you've done something to cooperate, or if you're doing something right now, or how you're planning to make a contribution in the future, and also how you make a living."

"Well . . . " Hyŏn, now feeling even more awkward, could do nothing but to simply stare at the detective's face.

"Anyway, it'd be better for you to be on record as doing something. Why don't you change your name? It's a very easy thing to do."

Suruda seemed to think that Hyŏn had not done this yet due to the inconvenience of the procedure. Once again Hyŏn made no reply.

"Low-level officers like me don't know very much, but from now on, nobody will be allowed to remain uninvolved."

"I agree with you."

Hyŏn was relieved by the fact that this summons did not mean imprisonment, as he had feared.

"In fact, I'm about to start something soon," he said, after some hesitation. "Please, file a favorable report for me."

On his way out, Hyŏn headed for a publisher whose chief editor had asked him to translate *A Chronicle of the Greater East Asian War.* The project had not been initiated by the publisher but was rather ordered by the Police Bureau. The editor advised Hyŏn that he had better demonstrate his loyalty if he wanted to exonerate himself in the eyes of the military, which had complained after he spoke Korean at the last meeting on the current situation; he had

fulfilled his obligation on that occasion by reading a passage from *The Tale of Chunhyang*.

Back in his study—which his wife, sympathetic toward her agitated husband, had cleaned with scrupulous care—Hyŏn emptied out a heap of Japanese newspaper clippings on the floor. Never before had his study looked so untidy.

Ever since I came of age, I have been living in a state of humiliation. In the forty years of my life, I've never experienced the joy of love, the privilege of youth, or the glory of art. Why should I write a war record in favor of Japan, and not a record of Japan's defeat instead?

Hyŏn really wanted to live. No, it's not that he cared overly for life itself, but that he wanted to make it through these times. Once, a German poet, who had placed all his hope on a socialist overthrow of the Nazi regime (the enemy of his country, humanity, and culture), committed suicide, in his rather simplistic despair, after Molotov shook hands with Hitler during the signing of the Russo-German Non-aggression Pact.

Hyŏn thought that the poet had rushed to judgment. Isn't the Soviet Union now fighting against Germany? The Americans, the British, and the Chinese are all fighting against Japan. Let's believe in an Allied victory! Let's trust in the justice of history! If history betrays mankind, there'll always be time to despair afterward.

Hyŏn did not sell his house. The second front had yet to materialize in Europe, and the Japanese army was announcing that it would defend Rabaul in the Pacific. Still, Hyŏn envisioned two or three more years of war at most. He borrowed what he could on his house and left Seoul. He went to a mountain village in the Kangwŏn province, partly because the local public doctor was an acquaintance of his. The leisurely, backward place, which was about twenty miles away by bus from the railway station, had its old magisterial office replaced with a resident office and a township office. He chose this town in the hope that his friendship with the doctor, who would likely have connections with town officials, would help him evade

the draft. Hyŏn was expecting to find enough food in the town, which was known for producing a variety of crops. He was also glad to have the Imjin River nearby so that he could spend his time fishing as he waited for better days ahead.

Yet when he actually arrived, none of these considerations worked out quite as he had anticipated. The head of the township office was no exception to the general contradiction of society at the time: he had as many certificates of merit on the walls of his office as he had earned complaints from the people. The doctor, a man of integrity who always called a spade a spade, had long before fallen out of favor with him. Besides, the doctor soon left for Seoul to complete a six-month-long training course, crushing Hyŏn's hope of being exempted from the draft. Other than the doctor, the only neighbor he knew was Kim, an old-fashioned scholar associated with the local Confucian school. The doctor had introduced them to each other. This old man, who still wore his hair up in a topknot, was remembered by the villagers only twice a year for the memorial rites he performed in the spring and fall. Kim's uncalloused hands, however, were not fit for looking after even his own household, let alone a friend's.

The river, which Hyŏn had thought would be near the village, turned out to be over two miles away. Not only was it too far for regular fishing, but the shortcut to the river also ran past the resident office. To avoid running into the police chief or his subordinates, Hyŏn had no choice but to climb a mountain to reach the river from a different direction. One day, as he turned the corner of the post office, Hyŏn caught sight of the Korean officer Kanemura. Startled, he took a step backward and quickly hid his fishing gear behind his back. Some township clerks were examining the tree bark brought by the villagers, and Kanemura was swaggering around the inspection site in his undershirt and gaiters, a sword at his side and a whip in his hand. Since the inspection seemed like it would take a while, Hyŏn decided to climb the mountain again this time.

He wandered around for a long time up along the slippery slope of the forest. When he finally reached the flat ridge of the mountain,

a dark, bearlike figure confronted him. It was the police chief. More startled at the sight of him than he would have been of any animal, Hyŏn dropped his fishing gear.

"Where are you going?"

"Oh, I just came up for some fresh air."

It seemed to Hyŏn that the chief was glaring at him. Hyŏn took off his straw hat and made a belated bow, but by then the chief had already turned around. The head of the township office was also there, and to their south lay a cordoned-off rectangular area, about the size of a tennis court. From the conversation between the two men, Hyŏn inferred that the site had been marked off for a *Shinto* shrine. Hyŏn stood as still as a post, not knowing what move to make next. He did not have the courage to pick up the fishing gear he had just dropped, let alone the nerve to pass through the shrine site, which would have meant crossing the cordon twice. Both men looked back at Hyŏn from time to time and then whispered something to each other. Had there been a flower nearby, Hyŏn could have pretended to pick it up, but there was not one in sight. After a while, as the two were looking in another direction, Hyŏn quickly gathered up his things—all evidence of his wartime idleness—and hurried back home.

"Dad, why'd you come back so soon?"

Hyŏn could not think up a good excuse for his children, but a neighbor's boy, who had followed him into the house, responded for him: "Your dad came back because he got caught by the chief."

On days when he could not go fishing, Hyŏn read books or visited Kim. And Kim often visited Hyŏn as well, should Hyŏn happen to be at home. The more often Hyŏn met, or rather attended on, the old and guileless Kim, the more he came to respect him as the only man of noble character in the town. At times, Hyŏn felt that "a man of rare integrity" must mean someone like Kim. After the demise of the Chosŏn dynasty, Kim had been to Seoul only once, when he was sent to prison during the March First Movement in 1919; other than that, he had never set foot in the capital, where the Governor-

General now reigned. He not only refused to adopt a Japanese name but had also made a point of wearing a topknot and a Korean top hat on the very day of his release from prison. Kim was older than Hyŏn by dozens of years. Hyŏn was unable to read Kim's classic poems, due to his poor knowledge of Chinese, and Kim could not discuss modern literature with Hyŏn out of his indifference to the new literature. But aside from this regrettable lack of communication on literary matters, they were able to talk heart-to-heart after just a couple of meetings. They both felt the fathomless misery of an ill-fated people and shared the same secret hope; their ardent hearts beat to the same rhythm, so much so that they could understand each other even without words.

One evening, Kim visited Hyŏn with traces of tears in his wrinkled yet spirited eyes. Hyŏn welcomed him by lighting a precious candle.

"Today, I whipped my grown-up nephew on the street."

Kim's hands were still trembling. One of his nephews worked at the township office. This nephew's brother-in-law, that is, the husband of Kim's niece, had run away after being drafted by the Japanese. The head of the township office discovered that the runaway had taken refuge at his in-laws and ordered Kim's nephew to arrest him. The draft-dodger realized what was happening and fled to the mountain. The nephew had the mountain surrounded with the support of the Reserve Corps. He captured his brother-in-law, as if the latter were a rabbit, and delivered him to the resident office.

"What a heartless man!" Hyŏn added with regret.

"My nephew was told that if he didn't turn in his brother-in-law, he'd be drafted instead. Still, how could he lead the Reserve Corps to his own brother-in-law, when he knew all too well what would happen to the poor man? Did he really have to join the Corps in throwing stones at him? Today's youths don't have any integrity."

"But then, at a time like this, can even parents really punish such behavior in public?"

"How could I hold back my anger? Who cares if we were on the streets! I caught him coming out of the office. I didn't say a word but

just beat him till my bamboo pipestem broke in two. He knew why he was being beaten. And even the onlookers, at least those who'd caught wind of what had happened, must have known. But what does it matter?"

It had been a gloomy day for Hyŏn as well. He had received a telegram from the Patriotic Association of Writers in Seoul, which ordered him to participate in an upcoming rally. The resident office, which had been counting every single postcard sent to Hyŏn, must have noticed the lengthy telegram. Even the Japanese postmaster seemed curious to know whether this man, who spent his days fishing during this state of emergency, would respond to the call of the writers' rally. One evening he asked Hyŏn's daughter if her father was going to Seoul the following day.

At first, Kim told Hyŏn not to go to the rally. But his discouragement only served to aggravate Hyŏn's anxiety about the consequences of not going. Over the next two days, Hyŏn received two more telegrams demanding his urgent reply. Kim found out about the telegrams on the second day and visited Hyŏn early that afternoon.

"Old men like me haven't got much left that needs to get done, even if we do live to see the new world, but a young man like you must survive and do your share of the work later. So don't be too stubborn over little things. Just try to escape the draft."

That day, Kanemura showed up to ask when Hyŏn was leaving for the rally, now only two days away. He wanted to know if Hyŏn needed any travel permits issued before he left; and if he wasn't leaving, why wasn't he attending the rally. On his way out, Kanemura said that he'd like to ask Hyŏn to take his pocket watch to Seoul for repairs.

"I want to survive!" Hyŏn cried once again inside. One day before the rally, he picked up Kanemura's watch and headed for Seoul in the rain to visit the Patriotic Association of Writers (PAW).

There was a reason behind Hyŏn's being telegraphed three times. A few days earlier, the main members of the PAW had invited seven or eight established writers, none of whom had shown much incli-

nation for cooperating with government policies, to a dinner with the chief of the Information Bureau. Since Hyŏn had been absent that evening, it would look good for him, and would help demonstrate the group's sincerity as a whole, if he could be persuaded to be one of the speakers at the rally. Hyŏn was asked to dedicate some sort of memorial as a representative for the novelists. Hyŏn remained uncommitted for a while, but since he had shown up, he could not hold out for long, so he followed them to the rally the next day. The rally at the Civic Center was an extravagant spectacle, with everyone wearing a khaki uniform or a ceremonial costume. The list of guests read as a who's who of the ruling elite: Lord So-and-so from the Governor-General's office, His Excellency Somebody-or-other from the Korean army, all dressed in stately attire or military uniforms; and among the writers in attendance there were many well-known names from Japan as well as from Manchukuo. It was the most glorious rally since the formation of the Korean literary society. Hyŏn wore a mud-stained jacket, which he used for fishing in the countryside, non-khaki-colored flannel pants, and no gaiters. He had no excuse for his inappropriate appearance, which was hardly befitting the wartime situation. But since there was no way he could spruce himself up on the spot, he simply entered the hall in what he was wearing. As he followed the course of all the proceedings, Hyŏn gradually became more engaged in the rally. Having grown accustomed to the simple sight of fish and to the artless sound of backwood orioles, he was jarred by the brutality of what he heard concerning the cultural policy of the Fascist regime. A certain Excellency even went so far as to cite Hitler, claiming that since a culture could be suppressed for a time and then later revived overnight when needed, whatever did not serve the current war effort, whether in art or literature, was better-off if eliminated altogether. Poets, critics, and novelists—the producers of culture—applauded the eloquent speeches of such armed Excellencies and talked themselves hoarse pandering to the vulgar taste of bureaucrats and soldiers, rather than protesting the decline of culture.

Hyŏn felt particularly sympathetic toward a pale, gaunt Manchukuo writer who read a congratulatory address in clumsy Japanese. Speaking in a foreign tongue, he looked so small and sad, and his face assumed such unnatural expressions. Most Korean writers were fluent in Japanese. Yet why does their fluency make them sound rather repulsive than agreeable? Hyŏn thought of the honor a dog or a pig retains since it could only utter sounds unique to itself. It was tantamount to a tragic resignation in the face of destiny for the people of a weak and small country to begin acquiring the language of the people of a bigger and stronger one. And yet it could not be said that the arguments and congratulatory addresses of the Japanese writers sounded any more natural or proper. From Hyŏn's perspective, the Japanese writers were even harder to understand. Yanagi Muneyoshi had once pleaded, "My brothers, abandon militarism. Abusing the weak does no honor to Japan. If we continue to sin against morality, the world will turn against Japan. When that happens, it will be Japan, not Korea, that will be ruined." There had also been cultural figures at one time in Japan who denounced Hitler's expatriation of the Jewish people—who had no nation of their own—and condemned the burning of books of philosophy and literature regarded as being too complicated. Where are they now? Why do they remain silent? Do they not have more freedom and a greater duty than Koreans or Manchurians to voice their candid concerns for the sake of their country and people? If the conscience of cultured men is really still alive in Japan, how could there be these many unsympathetic pseudo-religious figures who only try to paralyze the critical instincts of Koreans and Manchurians? Is it not a disgrace to Japan that its men of culture have become the pawns of a barbarous bureaucracy, the blind supporters of the "national" theater, "national" unity, and the elimination of the Korean language and culture from which their own originates? Of course, those with a conscience among the Japanese cultural elite must have their own troubles to worry about, too. Yet why are they being so complacent now?

Hyŏn was brought back from such reflections by the sound of applause. He realized that it was his turn to execrate even more malodorous words in Japanese than those of the Manchukuo writer earlier. His own facial expression would be even more contorted. When he thought of how he had been heaping blame on Japanese writers, Hyŏn could not help but ask himself: "What about you? Why are you sitting here?" It was as if he were in a nightmare in which he ran and ran only to find himself forever at the same spot. Mustering as much energy as he could to keep up this onerous running, he forced himself to stand. Unlike in a nightmare, however, once up from his seat he could walk away. Hyŏn sneaked out of the hall, where it seemed as if every eye were casting a hook for him. Outside, he remembered he'd left his hat behind.

What's going to happen? Chairman Kayama is going to call on me soon. The staff of the PAW will look for me, calling out my Korean name in front of all those high officials and officers!

Somebody was coming down the steps. Hyŏn slipped into the restroom. He heard the clanking sound of a sword. Its owner might well be the same Korean lieutenant who had earlier, in the hall's restaurant, told the writers that his sword would not forgive their necks should they fail to prove their loyalty as imperial subjects. The clanking sound now seemed to come from within the restroom. Hyŏn ducked into a stall. After a few moments the owner of the sword finished washing and left. But soon another pair of shoes could be heard entering the bathroom. Although no one would ever look into the stall, Hyŏn felt paralyzed, just as he had been when he had stumbled upon the police chief on the mountain ridge on his way to fish. The stall had a flush toilet but still smelled pungent. Hyŏn took out a cigarette and lit it. Even a prison cell wouldn't be this small or smell this bad; he laughed under his breath. Of all the places people go, the toilet is the worst to be stuck in for any other purpose than its intended one. Applause was heard from the third floor. It gradually subsided. Some time after the hall had quieted down, Hyŏn stepped out of the restroom. Saying to himself, devil

come what may, he ran, hatless, to his friend's place in Sŏngbuktong, far away from downtown.

Still, Hyŏn's trip to Seoul had not been in vain. Kanemura, who before had been too haughty to return Hyŏn's greeting, became more friendly ever since he received his repaired watch. And the police chief, the head of the township office, and the postmaster, who doubled as the chief air-raid warden, all seemed to think more highly of Hyŏn, whom the Writers' Association had invited to the rally by telegraphing no less than three times. They now greeted him right away when they came across him, so that Hyŏn could even go around carrying a fishing rod in their presence.

Hyŏn found fishing a peculiarly Asian pastime, maybe because his equipment and method were Asian. When the hook remained still, keeping him waiting, he felt like dozing off, leaving his mind under water. And when he occasionally began humming, despite his untrained voice, a *sijo* or a classic poem in Chinese seemed to suit him better than a modern poem.

A small village rests at the mountain's foot
The local office must have hung out a bell
Amid the birds' chirping I read a book
And I listen to a plea as the flowers fall
I'm called a poor official for my purse is thin
Though I'm free as a hermit with my leisure wide
With a fishing group I've newly joined in
I spent half a month on the riverside

This was the classic poem Hyŏn enjoyed reciting whenever he wanted to hum something. One time, as he was talking to Kim about different types of calligraphy, their conversation drifted to old memorial stones; so for a diversion, the two set off to see a row of stones dedicated to past local officers that stood along the village gate. The first in the row was the memorial of Kang Chin, whose

pen name was Taesan. Hyŏn saw it for the first time and was greatly surprised at the fact that the famous poet, who was known as the heir to the poetry of four eminent *Sirhak* literati, had once served as this small town's magistrate. On his way back, Hyŏn borrowed Kim's two-volume collection of Taesan's poems. Upon reading them later, he discovered that most of the poems, which the poet had written in his middle age, were composed in their very town. Hyŏn himself had already frequented most of the places that appeared in the literary magistrate's works: he sometimes climbed Mount Man'gyŏng, went fishing at the Nine Dragons' Pond, or passed by Tumundong, where a certain Ho, one of the surviving retainers of the Koryŏ dynasty, led a recluse life. Taesan seemed to have been content to retire to this scenic backwoods, having admired from an early age the leisurely style of Han Tuizhi, who sang, "Away I go to the beautiful countryside, I will read in a forest of pine and cinnamon trees." Taesan wrote his own poem to celebrate his idyllic life in the countryside: he received a modest pay, but he could read amid chirping birds, preside over a trial under falling blossoms, and spend half a month on the riverside with his fishing companions. If only holding an office were as easy as Taesan made it seem, Tao Yuanming would not have abandoned Pengze. Even if one's bound by official duty, as long as one finds pleasure in the wind and the moon, one has literature; and if one returns to the countryside, relinquishing an official post, there's still the same poetry of the wind and the moon to be enjoyed.

Read a book amid birds' chirping, and listen to a plea under falling flowers! Unfortunately, contemporary politicians can't indulge in such a romantic pastime while in office. Will there ever be a time again, Hyŏn wondered, when politics can be so romantic? Contemporary writers are also misfortunate, since they can't spend their time contemplating the wind and the moon. Will the days ever return when poetry can simply extol the pleasures of the wind and the moon? But then, why should such a time come at all? Or rather, could contemporary politicians and artists ever come to admire and honor such a life of leisure?

Although Hyŏn regularly recited Taesan's poem, he considered this habit a hobby, comparable to caressing the antique stationery of a bygone dynasty, and did not necessarily perceive any relevance between this hobby and his own literary life.

What has my own literary career been like? How different is it from the feudal idea of literature as a pastime?

Hyŏn did not develop this self-criticism after reading Kang's poems, nor did it begin with his move to the countryside, where he had more time for reflection away from writing. In fact, it had been a while since he came to look upon his past writings, mostly about personal subjects, with a critical eye. But if he had so limited his subject matters, he did so because he saw no better alternative. Hyŏn was against the proletarian literature of the leftists, for he was more concerned about the sorrow of Koreans in general rather than that of any particular class. At the same time, like any other Korean writer, he was too weak and isolated to directly criticize Japan's policy toward Korea. Sometimes, he felt a resentment seethe within him, as any ordinary man would, but under the brutal censorship he had no other choice but to submit and withdraw to the world of resignation.

So, what should I write? And how? It's all but inevitable that Japan will be ruined. Let's prepare in advance! But if Japan shouldn't lose? Then literature and culture won't even be a question in Korea. Since the Korean language will be lost, it's not just the language, but even the character of the people, that will be destroyed completely. Will history permit Japan to realize the horrors of such an imperialist scheme?

Hyŏn repeatedly assured his wife and Kim that the war would be over no later than a year from now, but he felt unsure and uneasy when he was alone. Yet his fear that the Fascist regimes might still triumph in the end soon disappeared. The reports in Japanese newspapers—such as Mussolini's downfall, the development of a second front, and the fall of Saipan—all made it clear that the outcome of the war had already been decided.

Still, Hyŏn was unable to resume his writing. He did not have enough spare thoughts in his head to read others' writings, let alone

to write himself. Although he recited, "Amid the birds' chirping I read a book / And I listen to a plea as the flowers fall," he could hardly concentrate on lengthy Western classics. Even after a year's worth of reading, he hadn't finished the second volume of *War and Peace*. Everyday he came home to face new worries—worries about food, wood, a tear in the papered floor, various inconveniences in the rustic kitchen, lack of shoes, lack of clothes, lack of medicine, and, lastly, the quickly dwindling funds on a loan he had drawn on his house in Seoul. He had expected the money to last for three years. A new law regarding the National Volunteer Corps expanded the age limit for draftees to sixty, but he had yet to secure his exemption. One day, the resident office summoned him. The rural office had not even bothered to send a directive; instead, a servant came to call on him. Yet the unease he felt was as unpleasant as always. One good thing, though, was that he needn't wait around nervously all day, as he would have had to in Seoul, but could go right away to find out what was wrong.

The resident office was packed with townsmen, right up to the door. Hyŏn quietly observed the scene to see whether the crowd had anything to do with his summons. The people had come to plea for food rationing. They were asking about how they were supposed to survive when their harvests of wheat and barley were being confiscated down to the last grain, with no ration given in return under the pretext of their being farmers; how they could increase production and make their quotas of wild vines, pine knots, and oak bark, when they themselves had nothing to eat. The head of the office, who had been smiling became straight-faced at the sight of Hyŏn. He came out to meet him.

"You didn't go fishing today, did you?"

"No, I didn't."

"The reason I didn't have you drafted for the Reserve Corps or the air-raid watch was to give you time to devote yourself to writing for the nation. But you keep going fishing, which makes a bad impression. Yesterday, when I visited the main office, they asked me who it was they always saw going on his way to fishing whenever

their bus passed by our town. Now, let's leave off fishing for a while, until our Japanese Empire consolidates its victory."

"Did they question you? I'm sorry," Hyŏn felt obliged to say.

"Also, you never show up when we give farewell parties here for the departing soldiers."

"I'm sorry. I'll come in the future."

Hyŏn was greatly disheartened. The summer's first rainy spell had just passed, and it was a time when nicely fattened fish were beginning to move around in schools. He'd been prohibited from fishing during the best season of the year. He shelved his fishing gear and spent his time talking to Kim, whom he now met more often than before. Whenever they met, they talked about the current state of affairs. In their optimistic reading of the latest events, they naturally dreamed of the day of liberation: Germany was already defeated, and Japan's enemy had landed on Okinawa.

"Did you say the name of the new nation will be Koryŏ?"

"They say the People's Republic of Koryŏ." Hyŏn had told Kim this once before, after he had first heard about it in Seoul.

"Why did they decide on 'Koryŏ'?"

"Because 'Koryŏ' is better known overseas than 'Chosŏn' or 'Taehan.' What would you call it?"

"Whatever the name is, I just hope the day of independence comes soon. But if possible, I would prefer the name Taehan."

"Taehan! Wasn't that the name briefly used at the end of the Chosŏn dynasty?"

"Yes. The Royal Court chose it, just like 'Silla' or 'Koryŏ.'"

"But what would be the point of calling the new nation Taehan, since we won't be returning to the Yi dynasty? Dynasties come and go. They're given different names at the whim of the king or his court, but hasn't the name of our people always been Chosŏn from the very beginning?"

"Well, that's true. *The Records of Three Kingdoms* also has plenty of names made from Chosŏn, like Kochosŏn and Wiman Chosŏn, but I wish . . . " Kim put down his pipe and sat up. "I want to name the nation Taehan, bring back King Yŏngch'in, and have him remar-

ried to a Korean woman, so I can serve the Yi dynasty one more time. . . . "

"You miss the last dynasty that much?"

"Of course. Not that an ordinary man like me abides by the old saying that thou shall not serve two masters, but shouldn't we have our independence restored right before the Japanese eyes and have a good revenge on those villains?"

"So you'd like to go to Japan as a Governor-General?" The two laughed lightheartedly.

"People's Republic of Koryŏ or what have you, does it have an army and the approval of the Allies?"

"I don't know how much it's worth, but it's already declared war on Japan, and its army is said to have over three hundred thousand soldiers, including the troops of Kim Ilsung, Kim Wŏnbong, and Yi Chŏngchŏn."

"Over three hundred thousand! What a large army! In the old days, an army of one hundred thousand was considered more than enough! Well, then, when we gain our independence and our government returns home, won't that be quite a sight to behold! Maybe I haven't lived this long in vain after all!"

Kim took up his pipe again. Amid the rising smoke, he pictured the stately image of the resplendent leaders of the Korean government being escorted by a great army of three hundred thousand soldiers. He sighed, as if overwhelmed with emotion, his eyes brimming with tears.

Soon afterward Kim was called in to the resident office. While he was there, the county chief called the town guardhouse to summon Kim to the county office. The next day Kim took the bus to the county office, which was over fifteen miles away. The headman welcomed him with a dinner at his official residence and asked Kim the following question:

"Why didn't you go to the provincial rally of Confucian scholars in Ch'unchŏn last month?"

"Is that why you summoned me?"

"No, not just for that."

"Please, go ahead and finish what you have to say."

"Aside from the past rally . . . you know, as well as I do, that the present situation doesn't permit anyone to remain uninvolved. Excuse me for saying this, but you seem too conservative. It's said that even a sage should follow the manners and ways of his time, and the general trend is not on your side."

"So?"

"This time round, before the National Confucian Rally, the county will give a lecture on national language and the imperial spirit. You should come to the lecture, and excuse me, but get a haircut and buy a khaki-colored uniform. You'll need it anyway, for the rally."

"Is that all?"

"Yes."

"Your Honor the Magistrate knows well that I'm a Confucian scholar. How can a Confucian be a Confucian, and what good would a Confucian rally be, if he can't follow the sage's teaching to preserve one's body, hair, and skin, which are all the gifts of his parents? It's not from personal honor that I've kept my position at the local Confucian school. Since there's nobody who can perform the procedures properly, I've taken charge of the memorial rites to fulfill my duty to the sages as a local scholar who strive to follow their steps. Now you're telling me to cut my hair, learn Japanese—even though I'm an old man who's losing his teeth—and change my clothes. It seems obvious that you want me to resign from my position. I get your point."

Then he took his leave. Yet within three days he was called again to the resident office. The order originated in a phone call from downtown like before, but this time he was to go to the police station. Kim went straight to Hyŏn.

"Mr. Hyŏn, they seem to be thinking of using force against me."

"Well, since their rage is on its last leg, try to avoid conflict and just ride things out."

"What if I ignore their call and refuse to go?"

"That won't do. Since they're now making arrests at the slightest provocation, they'll charge you for violation of an official order and cut your hair in prison. Then you won't be able to resist at all, just like in 1919."

"Right, you're right."

The following day Kim went downtown, yet he did not return as usual, not even after three days; the fourth day was August 15.

Hyŏn passed this historical day without noticing a thing, since the town had no radio and got its news only from newspapers, which were always delivered two or three days late. He sensed something only on the following morning, when he received a friend's telegraph, "Come to Seoul quickly." He visited the resident office to have a travel license issued, hoping as well to have a look around, but neither the office head nor the police officer on duty betrayed anything unusual. He obliquely asked Kanemura why Kim had not yet returned.

"Such a stubborn old man should sweat a little over there!"

"Then, is he in prison?"

"I don't really know. Don't go spreading any rumors." He didn't say anything further.

Nothing had changed.

"'Come to Seoul quickly,' what can this mean?" Hyŏn kept wondering about this as he waited for the bus. The bus arrived earlier than usual that day. Kim did not happen to return by this bus, either, and so Hyŏn had to leave without having a chance to see him. There was not one familiar face on the bus. Most of the passengers were wearing khaki uniforms, and no sign of change was visible. About ten miles down the road, Hyŏn's bus came across another bus heading in the opposite direction. The driver of Hyŏn's bus managed to stop the other by thrusting his arm out of the window.

"What's happened?"

"What do you mean?"

"You must have newspapers in Chŏrwŏn."

"The same as yesterday's broadcast."

"I couldn't hear clearly because of all the noise. By the way, didn't it say something about an unconditional surrender?"

When the conversation between the two drivers reached this point, Hyŏn sprang up in the crowded car before anyone else did.

"What are you talking about?"

"The war's over."

"What? Over?"

"It's all over now."

"Over! How?"

"Well, that's what I'm trying to find out."

"At last, Japan's lost the war," the driver of the other bus said. "If you go to Chŏrwŏn, you can read about it in the newspapers." Then he drove away. Hyŏn's bus, too, suddenly started moving again, and Hyŏn sank back into his seat.

"At last! What was fated to happen has finally happened! The long tedious waiting . . . " Hyŏn looked around at the other passengers, blinking his clouded eyes and trying not to get choked up. None of them looked Japanese, and yet they all appeared disinterested.

"Didn't you just hear what the driver said?" The passengers looked at each other but made no response.

"You know what'll become of Korea," Hyŏn asked again, "if Japan really has lost the war, don't you?"

"Whatever happens happens," responded an old man dressed in Korean clothes after a pause. "Who'd open his mouth these days without knowing for certain?"

"True. Just asking about it is frightening enough." Even the driver, who had shown some interest during the previous conversation, adopted the usual tired expression of a bus driver, revealing his wrinkles and sunken eyes.

Hyŏn lowered his head. He was more disconsolate at the stupefied look of his hapless compatriots than joyful over Korea's independence, and it made him want to cry. "Is all this merely a dream?"

After arriving at Chŏrwŏn, Hyŏn was finally able to read the *Seoul Daily* and confirm that it was not a dream. He duly made the

appropriate visits to people, shook their hands, and wept aloud together with them. The blue sky with its clouds like white blossoms, the fields with crops growing taller day by day, and the luxuriant trees—Hyŏn wanted to bow to each of them, then jump in the air and shout for joy.

At dawn on August 17, Hyŏn approached Seoul in an open sand truck packed with people, all busily talking about who would be president and who would be defense minister and shouting "Long Live Independence!" at the top of their voices. As each stop passed, and with it a sea of waving Korean national flags, Hyŏn was anxious that he might miss the National Independence Rally. The Rally was scheduled to take place at ten that morning.

He sensed something was wrong as he walked out of Chŏngnyangni Station. Despite his expectations, people in Seoul looked impassive, and only a few flags were to be seen. Downtown, spiteful Japanese soldiers were keeping guard at every corner, ready to respond swiftly to any provocation, and the *Seoul Daily* maintained its normal tone.

Hyŏn went to see the friend who had telegraphed him. As soon as they had shaken hands, Hyŏn asked where the National Independence Rally would take place. The friend answered that he did not know. Hyŏn asked further where the key members of the government were, as they were said to have returned by air. But the friend didn't know that, either. Hyŏn asked if the news of Japan's surrender was true at all. The friend said that it was. Feeling a sense of fatigue all over his body, Hyŏn sank into a chair and relaxed for the first time in many hours. Then his friend told him what had happened in Seoul in the two days since August 15.

Hyŏn was unhappy with what he heard of the situation in Seoul: the Governor-General and the Japanese army were still in command over Koreans, and while rumors circulated about the return of the Provisional Government from abroad, some were hatching their own plans for founding the nation. In the cultural sphere, while Hyŏn himself remained too dazed to tell whether it was all

real or only a dream, and while most writers had yet to arrive from their rural refuges, some were already hanging out placards, as if reclaiming their vested rights. Hyŏn found their move rash and suspicious. What disturbed him even more was the fact that those who hung banners and led the hurried assembling of a central cultural organization were mostly former leftists. Since neither the literary world nor the country as a whole was ready for the rampancy of the Left, he feared its possible takeover, which might lead to a catastrophic internecine conflict. Hyŏn thought that if he were to be honest with himself, he should not just be sitting around, so he visited the Central Council for the Construction of Korean Culture. There he found some of his old friends from the Club of Nine or from the magazine *Munjang*, but as he had expected, the core of the organization consisted of leftist writers and critics. They were revising a proclamation that had just been drafted. Hyŏn read it cautiously. He read it a second and third time. He was vigilantly searching for any hint of hypocrisy in their faces or behavior, yet he could not help but wonder, "Have they really prepared this much already for Korea's current situation?"

Once Hyŏn was informed of their positions and arguments, he had no objections to raise: their purpose was "to coordinate various cultural groups and to promote a harmonious dialogue between them, until the future Korean government establishes its cultural policies and creates an agency to implement them"; and their slogan was, "Liberation of Korean Culture, Construction of Korean Culture, and Unification of All Cultural Fronts." Hyŏn had also thought of united action as an important principle in the future path of the Korean people, Left or Right. Fearing that the leftists would diverge from this path, he had at first rashly turned against them. But all his worries were in vain. Their program was already quite concrete, but a class revolution was not in their priorities. This did not seem to be due to any hesitation or reservation on their part but rather to their genuine self-criticism and deep reflection on Korea's place in the current international situation. Otherwise, they could not have been content with such an apparently simple statement. Hyŏn con-

sidered this fortunate and gladly added his signature to the proclamation.

Nevertheless, he did not feel at ease. "All power to the people!"—flying banners and resounding songs were delivering this message and others from the meeting hall of the Council to the streets below. While this was a fine thing to say, it would not suit the people who were longing to see their nation, Taehan, emerge like a mirage on the sea. Absorbed in majestic fantasies and emotions, the people remained indifferent to their due rights. Hyŏn thought that the leftists were shouting, "All power to the people" not in advocacy of democracy but out of pure communist habit. In the previous century Hugo had already cried, "Not to the citizens but to the people," and so Hyŏn was well aware that "to the people" was neither a new nor a dangerous phrase in this age or in Korea's present situation; yet he was still wary, and many of his closer friends had indirectly expressed their concerns about Hyŏn's involvement with the group. Moreover, the political situation was growing more complex with each passing day. Members of the Provisional Government were not returning in a timely manner, not even individually, let alone making the grand appearance of which the people had been dreaming. In the north, the Soviet army was said to be routing the Japanese, thoroughly extirpating the enemy in full sympathy for the bone-deep resentments of Koreans. The American army, by contrast, was ignoring popular sentiment and had at first distributed leaflets making generous offers to the Japanese still in Korea. Such a measure consequently fuelled the continued boasting of the Governor-General and the Japanese army before the Korean people: "See, America still deals with Japan. A people like yours doesn't matter." Within Korea there appeared an organization calling itself the People's Republic of Korea, a development that augured future conflict with overseas powers; finally, a cultural activist group exclusively consisting of leftist writers was launched under the name of the Korean Proletarian Art Federation (KPAF), in opposition to the Central Council for the Construction of Korean Culture.

On the surface, the Council members, including Hyŏn, scoffed at the formation of the KPAF; "Neither history nor the present will permit them a separate existence." Yet, as sincere as the Council members were in their commitment to the unification of all cultural fronts, the KPAF's defection was an issue that urgently needed to be resolved. What particularly agitated Hyŏn was that the KPAF had announced a platform that did not differ much from the Council's. This suggested that the former leftists might be rejecting the Center for the Construction of Korean Literature (CCKL) specifically because their past adversary, Hyŏn, was its deputy chairman. At one point, right after the launching of the KPAF, some of Hyŏn's right-wing friends, as if they had been waiting for just that moment, took him out to a quiet place.

"We understand your intentions. But you won't be able to stay there much longer. All your efforts will be thrown away. In the end, So-and-so is more on the side of KPAF than on yours. Since you're likely to end up with nothing, despite all your efforts, let's organize our own group. Why disgrace yourself in the presence of such unbecoming company?"

Hyŏn told his friends that this time he would seriously reconsider his position. Then he parted from them. The very next day, a demonstration march sponsored by a leftist grassroots organization passed through Chongno. Of all the Allied national flags demonstrators carried only red ones and sang only the Red Flag Song. The crowds in the street adopted a reserved attitude toward the demonstration. But those in the Council building greeted the demonstrators with enthusiastic cheers and bursts of applause. To make matters worse, a senior member unwound the Soviet flags from the many prepared bundles of Allies' flags in the office, carried an armful of these red flags to the fourth floor, and scattered them over the procession, covering the street in red. Hyŏn ran up to stop him and prevented him from going back for a second load.

"Let's calm down."

"Why should we be calm?"

The two glared at each other. The young writers standing around the two all gave Hyŏn a contemptuous look. Instead of scattering red flags, they continued cheering the leftist demonstrators by shouting, clapping, and stamping their feet. After the procession passed, no one would come near Hyŏn. Upon leaving the hall, Hyŏn felt very alone. He was confident that if he were to resign, he could found a literary or cultural organization no smaller than the Council.

But . . .

Still . . .

Hyŏn slept on the thought. The following day he didn't go to the Council.

Why should I work only with friends who agree with me? What kind of effect could such a narrow clique have on this immense, new reality? The new freedom and independence of Korea should belong to all its people. Not only do I understand the leftists' ardor for a mass movement, but I, too, in good conscience, want to learn from them and make whatever contribution I can. All I want is to point out that waving red flags doesn't appeal to the public at this point, and that those supportive of the Red Flag don't account for all of the Korean people. If they don't understand me on this point and know no better than to interpret my views as merely reactionary, how can I continue to cooperate with them?

Hyŏn didn't feel like going to the hall the next day, either. As he was sitting idle and alone in his room, the man who had scattered the red flags over the demonstrators came for a visit.

"Hyŏn, you were quite upset the day before yesterday, weren't you?"

"Yes, I was."

"Hyŏn, I'll be honest with you. A Red demonstration, wasn't this the vision we've been dreaming of for so long? When I saw this vision out there, I lost my head and ran wild. To my shame. If it hadn't been for you, our recklessness would have gone farther. A man like you is worth ten of us in our present situation." His voice trembled at the end of his speech. After smoking a cigarette together in silence, the two got up and went back to the hall.

After the Red demonstration, Koreans, whether they were students, ordinary citizens, or intellectuals, seemed to split clearly into two camps, Left and Right. In the evenings, some of Hyŏn's friends would stop by to talk with him. Hyŏn was sincerely advised to make up his mind and withdraw from the Council, but he defended the organization, emphasizing that it was not as biased as it seemed. While at the hall next day, he received a phone call from friends whom he had met the night before.

"Either what you said was a lie, or you're being deceived as we told you. As evidence, take a look at the new slogan in capital letters, which was hung out this morning." They hung up the phone before Hyŏn could reply.

Hyŏn refrained from asking anyone around him about what he had just heard. He ran down to the ground floor and looked up at the four-story building from the street. He couldn't help but be surprised at what he saw. He had not noticed it on his way to the hall, but there was a cotton banner hanging from the rooftop to the second floor, which had "ALL SUPPORT FOR THE PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF KOREA" written across it in bigger letters than had been used in any previous slogan. The crowd in front of the Hwasin department store were straining their necks to look up at it. Their faces had doubtful, uneasy expressions. Hyŏn felt disheartened at this repeated betrayal. At the hall, neither the chairman of the Council nor the secretary had shown up yet. But the secretary of the CCKL was just then entering the building, following Hyŏn, and so Hyŏn led him by the hand to the rooftop.

"Who wrote that?"

"What?"

It was drizzling outside, so the secretary had not noticed the banner on his way in, either. It seemed that he had not been present at the meeting where the banner had been discussed.

"You really didn't know about it, either?"

"I honestly had no idea! Who in the world could have done it?"

"If neither of us knows, despite the fact that we've been here all along in the hall, then the absent members must be even more in

the dark about this. This is tyranny. If they're going to do things like this, then their talk about the unification of all cultural fronts is a lie. I don't want to trust them any more. I'm leaving, let them know."

Hyŏn turned away, but the bewildered secretary stopped him.

"Let's find out what happened first."

"It doesn't matter."

"*You're jumping to conclusions.*"

"They deserve it. I never thought that they would be so narrow-minded about their mass movement."

"Please, stay. If we part today, it's suicide for all men of culture in Korea."

"Then, why are you committing such a suicidal act?" Hyŏn had raised his voice unintentionally.

"I swear. I didn't know, either. But if we don't condemn this kind of thing and try to correct this misguided orientation, who will?" Tears began to fill the secretary's eyes.

Then he ran to the banner and set out to pull it up like an anchor cable—for every inch he dragged it up, the banner, which was wet and heavy on one side, slipped back half an inch. Soon, Hyŏn's eyes were moist, too.

"That's right!" Hyŏn cried inside, "It doesn't matter whether I'm used, duped, or mocked. The fact that I take offense at such things proves my lack of sincerity!" Hyŏn ran to help the secretary pull up the heavy banner.

Later, he learned that neither the chairman nor the secretary had known about the banner. After the People's Republic of Korea had been announced, a member of the secretariat wrote up the slogan on his own after the propaganda squad of the art department had asked him if there was anything to paint. He had been aware of the general opinion in the Council that whatever name the new nation might take, it should include "people's republic." The squad thought that the slogan was simple but important and thus wrote it across the entire length of the broad cotton cloth. Because hanging dry posters was their responsibility, they came in early before breakfast

and suspended it from the rooftop. For three months, the Council had to offer its excuse for this banner, which had been exhibited from just eight to eleven that one morning. The organization suffered quite a blow from this incident.

But this incident also provided an opportunity for all of the Council members to be more reflective in their self-criticism, their judgment of the political situation, and their campaign to bring the KPAF back into the fold.

With the arrival of the American army, the Japanese were no longer pointing their guns at Koreans, but as the leaflets had foreboded, the United States declared a military occupation. As for political parties, since anyone was eligible to found one, scores of them were created overnight. Dr. Syngman Rhee appeared amid the frantic cheers of the people and said that all Koreans should be one and united; meanwhile, traitors and profiteers resumed their activities, taking advantage of certain loopholes they spotted in Dr. Rhee's earnest words, as was the case of the former president of the colonial aviation company, who reemerged as the vice president of the new national airline. Politically, the people began to diverge more than converge, becoming more prone to suspicion rather than trust. The people could do nothing but invest their hope and faith in the Provisional Government, albeit in the form of individuals, as they had so deeply loved it and had fantasized for so long about following its leadership, to the extent of even disregarding their own rights. Yet a habit can be a hard thing to break for a group as well as for an individual. The Provisional Government, which had had no people to govern over during its years abroad, saw no need at all to talk to the people in Seoul now, far from addressing them from the makeshift podium of an oil carton in front of the Hwasin. Conflict with the KPAF was growing more acute, the 38th Parallel was ever tightening the waist of the Korean peninsula, robbery increased, and prices of goods soared—the question of trusteeship exploded at this time, just as the Korean people, after their protracted excitement, were on the brink of having a nervous breakdown.

All lost their calm. Outcries against trusteeship were raised here and there. Hyŏn, too, joined some of his friends at an anti-trusteeship rally, and his speech was published in a newspaper.

But Hyŏn, as well as those friends who participated in the rally with him, harbored misgivings and soon regretted what they had earlier said in their speeches. They gradually came to realize that the issue of trusteeship could not be so simply judged; after all, the Korean Communist Party raised the issue first. The Party's meticulous observations and precise judgments of the current political situation were something to appreciate; yet it was a great misfortune that the Party was the first to offer its support for the Moscow Agreement, since some people misunderstood the issue on account of this fact. Thus it became a subject of political disputes.

"We've been too hasty about trusteeship!"

"We made a big mistake!"

"Mistake? But we can't say that we really made a mistake, given public sentiments right now. It's also a good thing that we were able to articulate the pride of the Korean people as much as we did."

"But I mean there's a methodological difference between expressing our pride while understanding the situation and becoming enraged without knowing anything at all."

"Exactly! Since all this has just revealed how simplistic Koreans are and how lacking in real insight, what pride is there for us to talk about?"

"How can you work without ever making a mistake? Even Lenin said a man can't work without mistakes, and that whoever makes no mistakes is not working. Now that we know more, we should just try to do our best to effectively inform the public of the subtle international policy involved here."

As Hyŏn was discussing this matter with others, an old man, whose top hat made him look out of place, entered the hall.

"Oh my!" Hyŏn ran to greet him. It was Kim, who had often surfaced in Hyŏn's mind since the liberation. Kim had come to visit Seoul.

"Sir!"

"Mr. Hyŏn!"

"How's your health?"

"I'm feeling well enough for some sightseeing in Seoul."

But he looked very tired and weak, perhaps because he had walked a lot. He had had to ride a truck across the 38th Parallel from the north.

"When did you get here?"

"Yesterday."

"Where did you stay?"

"Well, I dropped by Chŏrwŏn on my way here and saw your family. They're all doing well and all want to come here."

Hyŏn's family had not been able to return to Seoul and was still staying at Chŏrwŏn.

"It's enough just knowing they're doing well."

"Since you, too, are far away from home, I first found a place to stay and then came right away to see you. So you all must be working hard?"

"Nothing really worth mentioning. I imagined how much you must be rejoicing. I've really been hoping to meet you. By the way, did you have a hard time when you went to the county police?"

"I almost lost my topknot. Luckily I escaped that."

"I'm so happy to see you."

It was about lunchtime, and since Hyŏn wanted to quietly reminisce about the past, he took Kim to an out-of-the-way restaurant.

"Mr. Hyŏn, I heard you've changed a lot."

"Me?"

"Rumor has it that you've changed much."

"Well . . . "

Hyŏn felt a bit disheartened. This was not the first time he had been told such a thing. Ever since the political scene had come to spilt clearly into conservative and progressive camps, he had seen many of his pre-liberation friends, who had once seemed willing to stand by him in an emergency, turn away from him at the mention of just one or two words, as if he were just a stranger. The political divide was causing rifts between friends.

"Mr. Hyŏn?"

"Yes?"

"How much did our people dream of independence? How much did we long for the return of the Provisional Government?"

"I know."

"Then why did you join the Communist Party?"

"Who said that I joined the Communist Party?"

"It's the talk of town. They say you're being used."

"Do you think so, too?"

"I know that you're not the type of man who can be tricked by anyone, though you might have changed your mind on your own."

"Thank you for saying that. As for having changed, I never had a clear enough standpoint before the liberation, so it's hard to say now whether I've changed or not. Most of my friends at that time were passive men of the world. Now that we're liberated, I don't want to just get by without actually doing some work."

"Does a man's way of life change after the liberation? A wise man doesn't live under suspicion."

"I disagree. At a time like this, if a person sees something's wrong, it's wiser to go against the grain than to worry about what others think of you. Just looking after your own affairs is a selfish attitude. Now is the most critical time for our nation, when we should exert ourselves, regardless of all the dangers, especially to our reputations."

"At any rate, a man should keep his moral obligations. What have we ever done? It's only right that we should absolutely obey those who have spent their lives overseas in a life-or-death struggle for the Korean people."

"I understand your point very well. And I'm no less grateful or deferential than anybody else to them. But the current situation is not that simple, either inside or outside Korea. You mentioned obligations, but think about what happened under the reign of King Kwanghae. After Ming helped Chosŏn during the Imjin War, Ming was attacked by Qing, and didn't Ming ask Chosŏn for reinforcements?"

"That gave a rise to the dispute over loyalty in Chosŏn."

"Chosŏn had no capacity to help Ming in the new war, since the Imjin War had just finished. But the Ming loyalists argued that on principle, they could not stand by, even if this meant the ruin of Chosŏn along with Ming. On the other hand, their critics gave priority to the people over the principle, arguing that the people should not be plunged into more misery so soon after their recent suffering at the hands of the Japanese, even if Chosŏn's refusal disgraced the throne or the whole dynasty. Didn't King Kwanghae support the latter view to the extent of being dethroned himself? I believe that King Kwanghae, who abandoned his throne like an old shoe, saying that the impoverished people should not be made to suffer in a fight between kings or dynasties, was a truly virtuous leader—far better than those who worried only about the interests of the ruling class, regardless of what would become of the people. Besides, why should we feel obliged only to those who came from abroad?"

"But they fought for national independence in foreign lands for twenty-seven or twenty-eight years, and so don't they stand out for their irreproachable integrity?"

"By no means am I trying to cheapen their hardships. Anyone who has faithfully continued to fight for us, either at home or abroad, deserves our respect. You talk about hardships and life-or-death struggles, but as for bleeding under torture or suffering the numbing pain of cold hands and feet, I think those who've fought at home and been dragged to detention cells and prisons had it many times worse. And physical suffering wasn't all of it. They also had to fight against all kinds of repeated threats and enticements to win them over mentally, so I think if a man fought at home without changing his mind, he's the greatest fighter."

"You're advocating only the communists!"

"Was everyone at home a communist? Right now, the Communist Party is wise enough to set its goal not on a proletarian revolution but on a capitalist, democratic one for all of Korea. There's no place, then, on principle, for a polar division between Left and Right, and for the most part they're succeeding in keeping such di-

visions and disputes among Koreans to a minimum. For the sake of Koreans, I think this is a very good sign."

"I don't understand what you're talking about, but I still think the fault lies with the Communist Party."

"Why don't we drink?"

"What does an old man know . . . " Kim did not hold his alcohol well. His face soon turned red. "But even at my age, a man has dreams. If only the communists remain quiet, we'll soon have our independence, and the key figures of the Provisional Government will take their due positions, which they've earned through their suffering. And won't they make good rulers? Wasn't it the communists who caused the problem of trusteeship with their senseless fighting?

Kim was quite angry. He said that Korean independence was being blocked by the Soviet Union overseas and the Communist Party at home. Hyŏn found it impossible to enlighten someone like Kim, who had no knowledge of history or international affairs but simply believed that liberation came as a result of a war of independence. Such a task required a certain skill, one which Hyŏn did not have. He just smiled and urged Kim to eat more food.

Kim visited Hyŏn again the next day, and Hyŏn returned his visit the day after that.

"Why are you in favor of trusteeship?" Kim asked when Hyŏn visited him.

"I'm not in favor of it."

"Then are you supporting trusteeship, something you don't even like, merely because the Provisional Government's against it and you want to oppose everything it does?"

"You can be quite radical, too."

"Should I just let myself be sold off at the end of my life to the foreign ministers of three countries and be dragged into trusteeship without any protest?"

"That's a bit extreme! Do you think I've got such bright prospects now that I've sold my support for the Moscow Agreement?"

Kim made no reply, but he did not hide his disapproval of Hyŏn's position. Hyŏn tried his best to avoid provoking Kim and to explain

his reasoning: since liberation had been achieved not by the power of the Koreans themselves but by an international alliance, it can't exist now outside the sphere of international politics; he supports the Moscow Agreement not because he favors, or is happy with, trusteeship but because Korea is caught between the capitalist United States and the socialist Soviet Union and needs to secure an international guarantee of its national independence and neutrality; otherwise, if the Soviet Union, the United States, and China all start their own underground diplomacy in Korea, where the government and economy are still fragile, Korea will fall into an ultimately ruinous internecine dispute, just like the time when King Kojong had to take refuge in the Russian embassy at the end of Chosŏn; so, Korea has no choice now but to seek an international warrant of its hard-won freedom; since this victory wasn't won through a war of independence led by the Yi dynasty, deluding the public by chanting Taehan, Taehan in some nostalgic call for the imperial period of the feudal dynasty isn't the right way to lead the Korean people to true happiness; and since the United States and the Soviet Union are in every respect the most pragmatic of all nations, Korea won't be able to deal with them, unless it arms itself with a cogent international perspective and makes a thorough preparation, without relying on illusions based on emotions. Hyŏn emphatically tried to explain his position, but Kim, who used to praise Hyŏn as a man of rare integrity before the liberation, obstinately refused to understand him at all. He simply found it disagreeable that Hyŏn, as a Korean, should be criticizing Taehan. He kept insisting on his own explanation that the trusteeship must be the result of some evil communist scheme.

Kim did not return for a while after that. Hyŏn didn't visit him either, partly because he was too busy but also because he no longer cared for Kim.

The trusteeship proved to be an onerous political trial for Koreans. If an opposition demonstration took place one day, the supporters of the Moscow Agreement marched in the streets the next. The masses collided, and there were leaders who exploited this con-

flict, making their scramble for political power all the more vicious. In the end, students, who had borne the brunt of the national ordeal before liberation again bore the cross during this unfortunate time.

On one of these gloomy days, Kim visited Hyŏn at the hall. He was returning to the countryside that day. Hyŏn invited him out to lunch, but Kim turned down the offer, unlike on previous occasions, and also deterred Hyŏn from coming downstairs to see him off. He seemed to have stopped by just to say a good-bye, for the sake of their old friendship, but did not care for Hyŏn's treating him or paying him any courtesies.

"When will you come to Seoul again?"

"I don't want to come back to this Seoul. When I return, I'll settle in the seclusion of Tumundong." Kim then resolutely walked down the steps without once looking back.

Hyŏn stood there for a while, stupefied, before going up to the rooftop to get some fresh air. Amid the American Jeeps swarming like whirligig beetles, Kim cut a very conspicuous figure in his white overcoat and black top hat. Hyŏn thought of Wang Guowei, a scholar at the end of the Qing dynasty. When Wang went to Japan to give a lecture on Ming's songs, Hyŏn had also gone to see him. Wang was still wearing his hair in Qing-style pigtail. The Japanese students sniggered at him, but Hyŏn, who did not have a nation of his own, became teary-eyed, thinking of the scholar's loyalty to the passing dynasty, and admired his integrity. Later, Hyŏn heard that Wang had gone to Shanghai and then on to Peking only to witness the vanishing shadow of his beloved dynasty wherever he wandered. When he drowned himself in Lake Kunming—after singing, "The blue water and the green mountain have not changed / The rain washes the moss off of a stone beast"—he was still wearing his pigtail. Yet when Hyŏn came to think of it now, what destroyed Qing was not foreign enemies but a revolution for truth and the happiness of the Chinese people. Although Wang's affectionate devotion to his king was admirable, had he devoted his passion and life to the revolution, wouldn't it have made him a greater man and his life

even more honorable, a life committed to a larger truth? Hyŏn gazed at Kim's back as it disappeared into the distance. The figure of the old man, who had braved the 38th Parallel to come to the old capital in search of Taehan and who still wore a topknot, which he had managed to preserve despite all the abuse and contempt he received during the colonial period, was now drifting away, like a speck of dust, below the great waves of world history. Hyŏn could not help but recall the pitiful last moments of the Chinese scholar.

The wind was still chilly, but there was already a hint of a soft spring breeze. Hyŏn smoked one more cigarette and went down to the hall. His friends had concluded the union with the KPAF and were busy preparing for the Writers' National Rally.

(March 23, 1946)